to defeat the Chinese People's Liberation Army and take revenge on China for India's defeat in the 1962 border war. I'd love to tell them that there was not much difference between China and India in terms of economic strength in 1962, but today, China's GDP is about five times that of India and China's military expenditure is over three times that of India according to Western estimates. If India escalates the border dispute with China into skirmishes or even local wars, it would be like an egg dashing itself against a rock.'[104]

In sum, from three perspectives, China affirms a hierarchy in world politics, with itself at the top. India features at best in the second tier of Asian countries, perhaps not even in the second tier globally, where Beijing would likely place Russia, Japan, the UK, and France. Zhang's depiction of China in terms of superlatives is indicative of the Chinese view. This is not just an elite's triumphalism. In 1998, some weeks after South Asia's nuclear tests, I was invited to give two lectures at Fudan University in Shanghai to a group of Chinese, Indian, and Pakistani students assembled for a month-long workshop on nuclear arms control. Before and after my own lectures, I attended some of the other sessions. During one of these, an Indian student commented that in the middle of the twenty-first century India would surpass China in population terms. She quoted a United Nations estimate to make her point. It was a casual remark and not the burden of her intervention. However, as soon as the words were spoken, a Chinese student asked to be recognized. I remember her matter-of-fact words: 'On China and India's population, I would like to say that China can never be behind India. That is impossible. It is not based on facts.' She was an affable and pleasant young woman, as we discovered in the evening's social gatherings, and there was no animosity in her voice – it was more a mixture of shock and exasperation. The idea that India could surpass China in any way was a childish fantasy to her – and fantasy was not admissible in the rational setting of the conference hall.

At the same workshop, when discussion turned to nuclear weapons, we were reminded of the Chinese attitude to India's size. When a Western expert criticized India's nuclearization, an Indian student aired the view that